

How Executive Institutions Shape Affective Polarization: Evidence from Israel, 1975-2001

Supplementary Information

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S1 Countries and Institutional Coding

In the main text, I describe my decision to code countries as “presidential” only if their head of government satisfies two criteria: they are elected separately from the legislature (or appointed by a head of state who is also not chosen by the legislature) and they serve a fixed term in office, with no need to rely on the legislature for confidence. This coding scheme ensures, in line with my theory, that I only consider countries presidential if their institutional design provides both separate origin and separate survival for the executive.

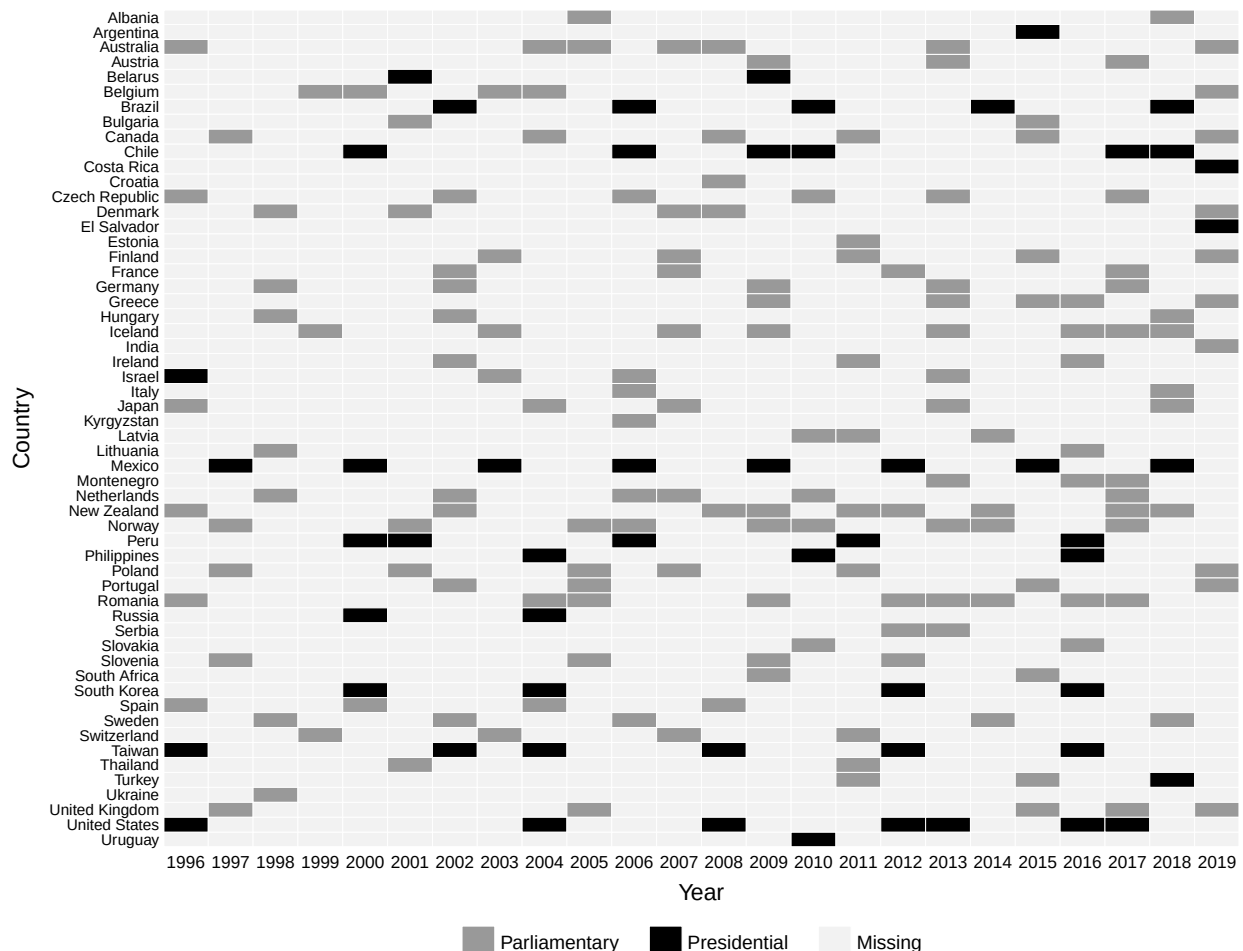


Figure S1: Country-Year Institutional Coding, Cross-National Survey Analyses

Figures S1 and S2 show the country-years included in cross-national survey and synthetic control analyses, respectively. Black cells indicate country-years coded as presidential, while dark gray cells indicate country-years coded as parliamentary. Light gray cells indicate country-years that are not included. Country-years may be missing for a different reasons. In Figure S1, missing country-years are most often due to surveys not being fielded in that year. In Figure S2, countries are left off the plot entirely if they did not have parliamentary-style executive institutions for the entirety of the time period under consideration (1975-2001). Countries that had presidential institutions or oscillated between the two cannot serve as control units and therefore are not included

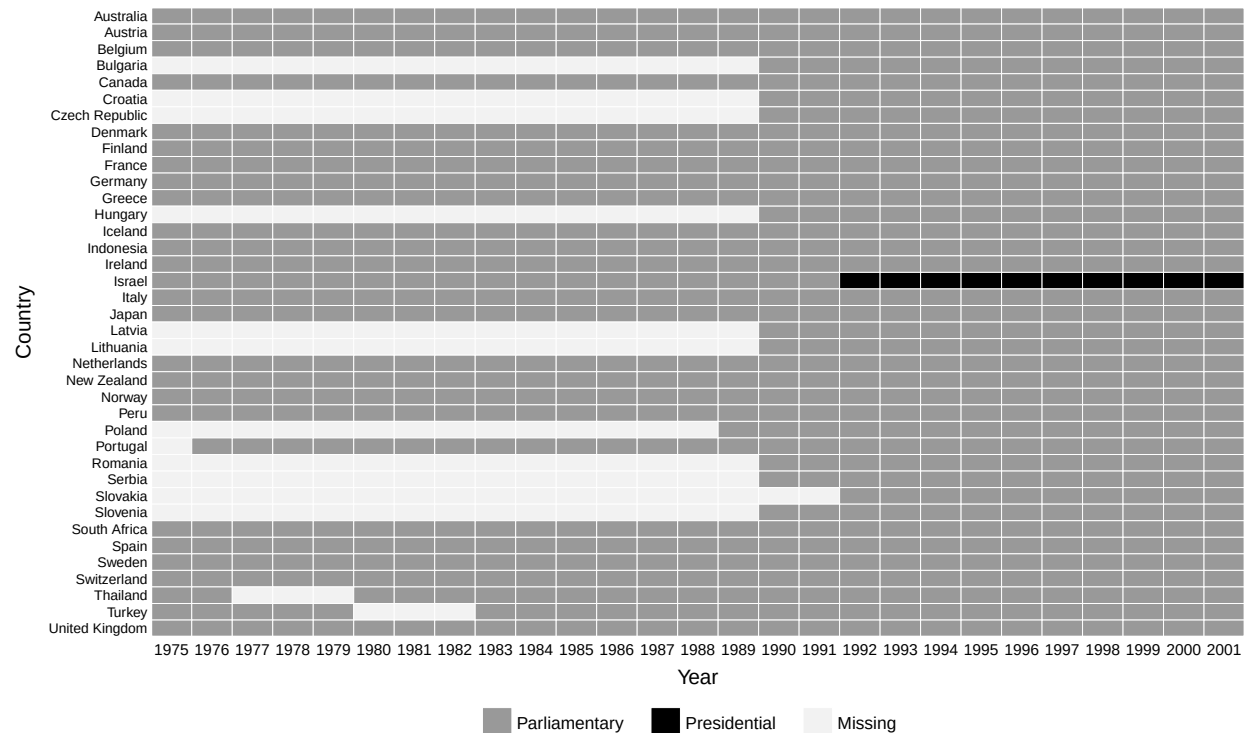


Figure S2: Country-Year Institutional Coding, Synthetic Control Analyses

in the synthetic control analysis. Across all analyses, I do not provide any institutional coding in country-years where a state was governed by an autocratic or military regime, an exclusion which causes, for instance, the brief interregna observed in Thailand's and Turkey's time series. Finally, many countries—particularly in Eastern Europe—did not yet exist as separate states in the early part of the time series. Below, I clarify how the synthetic control estimator handles these unbalanced panels.

An alternate coding scheme would be to consider countries with *either* separate origin or survival as presidential, thereby grouping semi-presidential systems under the “presidential” label. Samuels and Shugart (2010) recommend considering semi-presidential systems as more similar to presidencies than to parliamentary systems, which would suggest a coding scheme such as this one. Figures S3 and S4 display country-year coding under this alternate scheme, similar to Figures S1 and S2. Elsewhere in the Supplementary Information, I present results of empirical analyses using this coding scheme.

However, my decision to require both separate origin and survival as criteria for being considered presidential aligns more closely with other datasets providing cross-national coding of executive institutions. Two-sample t -tests assessing the value of the presidentialism index from the Varieties of Democracy project (V-Dem; Coppedge et al. 2020) shows that presidential and parliamentary institutions are better separated under this coding scheme ($\delta = 0.707$, $t = 22.2$) than under the alternate coding scheme that considers semi-presidential systems as presidential ($\delta = 0.57$, $t = 19.838$). The difference between these two differences-in-means is statistically significant ($\beta = -0.138$, $p < 0.001$). The same is true when comparing the two coding schemes to the presidentialism index from the Database of Political Institutions (DPI; Cruz et al. 2021):

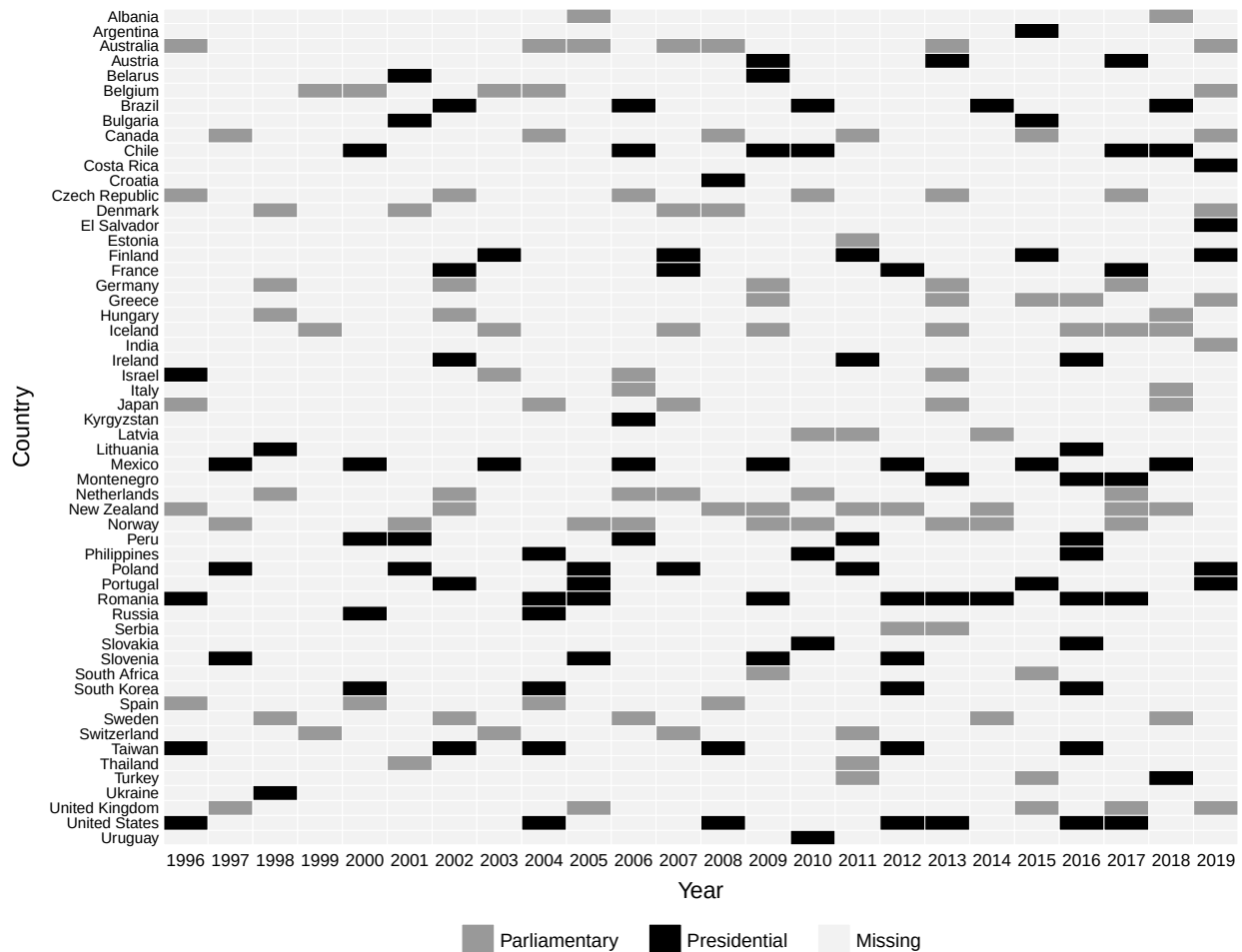


Figure S3: Alternative Country-Year Institutional Coding, Cross-National Survey Analyses

$\delta = 0.799$, $t = 77.674$ for the main coding scheme and $\delta = 0.685$, $t = 55.6$ for the alternate scheme. The difference between these two differences-in-means is also statistically significant ($\beta = -0.114$, $p < 0.001$).

Although I need to categorize institutional designs according to a coarse coding scheme in order to identify treatment effects, this can leave questions about the many variations on designs that do not fit neatly into one category or the other. On one hand, semi-presidential subtypes such as premier-presidential or president-parliamentary systems are classified as “parliamentary” under this coding scheme because they have fused survival mechanisms (Shugart and Carey 1992). On the other hand, heads of government may carry the “presidential” label while actually remaining quite accountable to the legislature, a feature that might suggest the case needs to be coded as “parliamentary” here. Below, I highlight a selection of edge cases in the main coding scheme and clarify my coding decisions in each.

Austria Austria’s head of government is the Federal Chancellor, who is appointed by the popularly elected President. However, the Chancellor requires the confidence of the National Council to remain in office and can be removed at any time (Müller 2003), thus lacking separate survival.

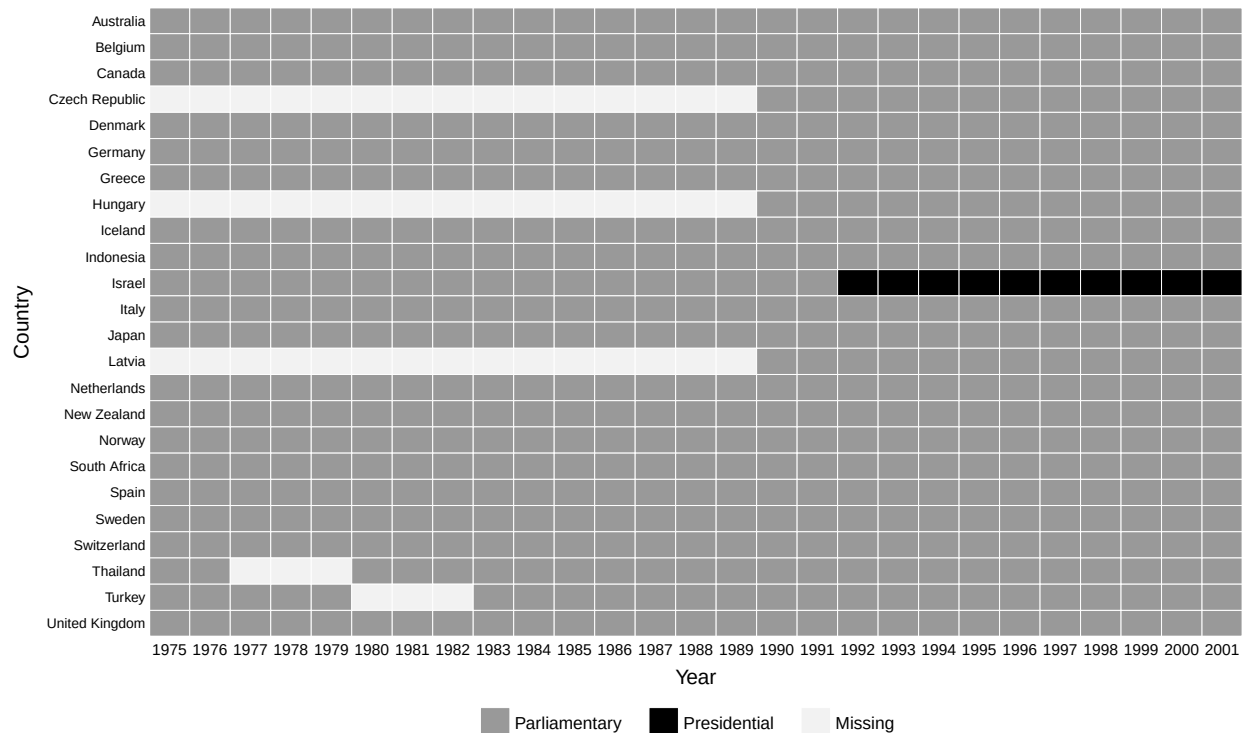


Figure S4: Alternative Country-Year Institutional Coding, Synthetic Control Analyses

Bulgaria Bulgaria’s system is often described as “parliamentarized semi-presidentialism” (Siaroff 2003). Their head of government is the Prime Minister, who is formally appointed by the popularly elected President. In most cases, this is a *pro forma* appointment offered to the leader of the largest party or coalition in the National Assembly. The Prime Minister must maintain the confidence of the National Assembly and can be dismissed by a no-confidence vote (Elgie 2011). Both origin and survival are thus fused.

Croatia Under the 1990 constitution, Croatia had a strong semi-presidential system in which the President exercised considerable authority and could dismiss the Prime Minister at will. Even under this arrangement, however, the Prime Minister was formally accountable to Parliament, lacking separate survival. Constitutional amendments around the turn of the century transferred most executive authority to the Prime Minister, effectively converting Croatia to a parliamentary system (Kasapović 2012).

Finland Finland’s president has been directly elected since 1994 and historically wielded significant powers, particularly in foreign policy and government formation. However, the Prime Minister is head of government and has always served at the pleasure of Parliament. The 2000 constitution further reduced presidential powers, transferring authority over government formation to Parliament and cementing the Prime Minister’s dependence on parliamentary confidence (Nousiainen 2001).

France France is the paradigmatic case of semi-presidentialism (Duverger 1980). The President is directly elected, exercises substantial executive authority, and appoints the Prime Minister, who serves as the head of government. However, the Prime Minister can be dismissed by the National Assembly, effectively requiring the President to select a Prime Minister with parliamentary support. At any rate, the requirement for parliamentary confidence marks a lack of separate survival.

Lithuania Lithuania operates a premier-presidential system in which the President is directly elected but the Prime Minister serves as head of government and is elected (and can be removed) by the Seimas (Elgie 2011). Both origin and survival are thus fused.

Peru Peru is perhaps the most ambiguous case. The President is directly elected and serves as the head of government with a fixed term, which would ordinarily suggest a presidential classification. Peru's unique institutional configuration lies in the interpretation of Congress' power to impeach and remove the President. Although the 1993 constitution provides many reasons a President can be removed, impeachment proceedings in practice most often stem from a charge of "moral incapacity," a vague term left up to interpretation by Congress (Brown 2024). Parties in Congress have wielded this charge liberally, applying it to situations ranging from corruption scandals to policy disagreements to political expediency (Cassinelli 2025). As a result, "leaders without significant support in Congress face a constant threat of removal" (Sanborn and García Nice 2023). The fate of Peru's modern-day presidents shows how far off the rails this arrangement has gone in recent years: seven presidents have left office since 2018 due to impeachment or the threat thereof, leading one Latin American media outlet to describe impeachment as "a political crowbar wielded whenever Congress wants to pry open the presidency" (The Latin American Post Staff 2025). Because the President's survival depends on the confidence of Congress *in practice*, I consider Peru to have not satisfied the requirements for separate survival.

Poland Poland's Prime Minister is appointed by the directly elected President but must receive a vote of confidence from the Sejm. In the case that the confidence vote fails, the Sejm assumes the power to nominate the Prime Minister. As a consequence, the President must nominate Prime Ministers who have parliamentary support. The Prime Minister can then be removed by the Sejm through a vote of no confidence (Jasiewicz 2008). The head of government thus lacks both separate origin and separate survival from the legislature.

Portugal Portugal's popularly elected President appoints the Prime Minister, who must maintain the confidence of the Assembly of the Republic. The 1982 constitutional revision substantially curtailed the President's power to dismiss the government (Costa Lobo 2005), and the Prime Minister is typically the leader of the largest party or coalition in the Assembly. Portugal's Prime Minister thus lacks separate survival.

Romania Romania's popularly elected President nominates a candidate for Prime Minister in consultation with Parliament. The candidate must receive a vote of confidence from both parliamentary chambers to be appointed. The Prime Minister can be removed by a vote of no confidence (Roper 2002), indicating that Romania lacks separate survival.

Serbia Under the 1990 constitution, Serbia's President was directly elected with broad formal powers. Nevertheless, the Prime Minister was the head of government and formally accountable to the National Assembly (Spasojević 2022). The 2006 constitution established a more parliamentary system with a largely ceremonial presidency. Under both arrangements, the head of government lacked separate survival from the legislature.

Slovakia Before 1999, Slovakia's President was elected by the National Council, making the system straightforwardly parliamentary. A constitutional amendment in 1999 introduced direct popular election of the President (Malová and Rybár 2012). Even after this change, the Prime Minister remains the head of government and requires parliamentary confidence, thus lacking separate survival.

Slovenia Slovenia's directly elected President nominates the Prime Minister following consultation with the National Assembly (Cerar 1999). In practice, the Prime Minister is typically the leader of the largest party or coalition in the National Assembly. Because the Prime Minister must be elected by the National Assembly, they are typically the leader of the largest party or coalition in the Assembly. The Prime Minister can be removed through a vote of no confidence, thus lacking either separate origin or separate survival.

Switzerland Switzerland is a unique case, often referred to as "assembly-independent" (Shugart and Carey 1992). The Federal Council serves as a collective head of government and state, with seven members elected by the Federal Assembly. Presidential duties rotate among members, and they are not subject to parliamentary confidence. The Council is not subject to Assembly confidence, making origin fused but survival separate.

S2 Cross-National Survey Evidence

Tables S1 and S2 provide full results of the models displayed in main text Figure 1. In Table S1, I also add results from another model, not discussed in the main text, where the dependent variable is the difference in respondents' affect toward their own party and the largest out-party. This variable is mechanically related to the in- and out-party affect levels discussed in the main text, but by explicitly calculating the difference between them, it more directly captures the inter-group heterogeneity aspect of affective polarization. I also add a model of the proportion of respondents expressing a party identity in Table S2. This complements the model discussed in the main text, where the dependent variable is the proportion of respondents feeling their views are well-represented by a party. I believe the latter is a more appropriate variable to capture the theory's predictions, but results are similar across both specifications, particularly in bivariate models.

Tables S3 and S4 replicate the models in Tables S1 and S2 using the alternate scheme of coding institutional designs discussed in section S1. Results are broadly consistent across coding schemes, save for a couple instances of variation in statistical significance.

Table S1: Institutional Differences in Party Affect and Perceptions (1 of 2)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>							
	Level of In-Party Affect		Level of Out-Party Affect		Difference in Party Affect		Variance of Perceived Party Ideology	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Presidential	−0.577*	−0.526*	−0.065	0.087	−0.096	−0.309*	0.881*	0.400*
	(0.147)	(0.174)	(0.145)	(0.173)	(0.138)	(0.151)	(0.160)	(0.192)
Democracy		−0.186		0.001		−0.137		−0.641*
		(0.210)		(0.253)		(0.227)		(0.221)
GDP		−0.078		0.205		−0.411*		−0.366*
		(0.133)		(0.158)		(0.156)		(0.127)
Gini		0.0002		−0.101		0.107		0.221*
		(0.078)		(0.077)		(0.081)		(0.052)
Eff. Parties		0.342*		0.448		−0.260		0.110
		(0.126)		(0.237)		(0.193)		(0.141)
Intercept	0.178*	0.409*	0.071	−0.127	0.004	0.527*	−0.223*	0.648*
	(0.073)	(0.194)	(0.078)	(0.179)	(0.079)	(0.186)	(0.070)	(0.166)
Observations	224	216	223	215	223	215	214	208
R ²	0.065	0.071	0.001	0.066	0.002	0.137	0.140	0.419
Adjusted R ²	0.061	0.048	−0.004	0.044	−0.003	0.116	0.136	0.404

Note: *p<0.05. Heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors in parentheses.

Table S2: Institutional Differences in Party Affect and Perceptions (2 of 2)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>							
	Variance of In-Party Affect		Variance of Out-Party Affect		Proportion Feeling Represented		Proportion with Party ID	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Presidential	0.705*	0.325	0.403*	−0.006	−0.326*	−0.112	−0.344*	0.078
	(0.157)	(0.211)	(0.172)	(0.164)	(0.134)	(0.163)	(0.158)	(0.144)
Democracy		0.032		0.200		0.023		−0.023
		(0.220)		(0.202)		(0.195)		(0.148)
GDP		−0.701*		−0.893*		0.307*		0.606*
		(0.151)		(0.114)		(0.141)		(0.117)
Gini		0.111		0.006		0.086		0.078
		(0.090)		(0.063)		(0.082)		(0.085)
Eff. Parties		−0.179		0.261*		−0.068		−0.424*
		(0.122)		(0.103)		(0.142)		(0.110)
Intercept	−0.160*	0.512*	−0.073	0.676*	0.072	−0.283*	0.162*	−0.459*
	(0.075)	(0.251)	(0.074)	(0.153)	(0.082)	(0.121)	(0.066)	(0.134)
Observations	221	213	220	212	226	218	226	218
R ²	0.089	0.324	0.030	0.354	0.019	0.064	0.026	0.253
Adjusted R ²	0.085	0.307	0.025	0.338	0.015	0.042	0.022	0.236

Note: *p<0.05. Heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors in parentheses.

Table S3: Institutional Differences in Party Affect and Perceptions (Alternate Coding, 1 of 2)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>							
	Level of In-Party Affect		Level of Out-Party Affect		Difference in Party Affect		Variance of Perceived Party Ideology	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Presidential	−0.263*	−0.236	0.032	0.233	0.032	−0.246*	0.796*	0.366*
	(0.130)	(0.166)	(0.131)	(0.133)	(0.130)	(0.121)	(0.128)	(0.128)
Democracy		−0.160		−0.019		−0.116		−0.675*
		(0.212)		(0.253)		(0.223)		(0.204)
GDP		−0.060		0.270		−0.436*		−0.315*
		(0.156)		(0.159)		(0.153)		(0.129)
Gini		−0.034		−0.095		0.087		0.243*
		(0.084)		(0.079)		(0.086)		(0.051)
Eff. Parties		0.306*		0.451		−0.279		0.140
		(0.137)		(0.242)		(0.191)		(0.144)
Intercept	0.159	0.375	0.041	−0.257	−0.034	0.582*	−0.393*	0.538*
	(0.090)	(0.225)	(0.097)	(0.188)	(0.098)	(0.201)	(0.070)	(0.150)
Observations	224	216	223	215	223	215	214	208
R ²	0.018	0.037	0.0003	0.075	0.0003	0.135	0.161	0.422
Adjusted R ²	0.014	0.014	−0.004	0.053	−0.004	0.114	0.157	0.408

Note: *p<0.05. Heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors in parentheses.

Table S4: Institutional Differences in Party Affect and Perceptions (Alternate Coding, 2 of 2)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>							
	Variance of In-Party Affect		Variance of Out-Party Affect		Proportion Feeling Represented		Proportion with Party ID	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Presidential	0.651*	0.189	0.656*	0.225	−0.241	0.011	−0.527*	−0.163
	(0.131)	(0.208)	(0.134)	(0.118)	(0.133)	(0.154)	(0.120)	(0.134)
Democracy		0.012		0.181		0.023		−0.009
		(0.215)		(0.201)		(0.191)		(0.149)
GDP		−0.697*		−0.811*		0.333*		0.533*
		(0.188)		(0.119)		(0.147)		(0.125)
Gini		0.132		0.006		0.079		0.084
		(0.088)		(0.060)		(0.081)		(0.083)
Eff. Parties		−0.155		0.257*		−0.077		−0.418*
		(0.131)		(0.105)		(0.141)		(0.109)
Intercept	−0.294*	0.503	−0.281*	0.517*	0.106	−0.333*	0.325*	−0.316
	(0.089)	(0.302)	(0.067)	(0.124)	(0.105)	(0.158)	(0.072)	(0.161)
Observations	221	213	220	212	226	218	226	218
R ²	0.102	0.316	0.106	0.364	0.014	0.062	0.082	0.258
Adjusted R ²	0.098	0.299	0.101	0.348	0.010	0.040	0.078	0.241

Note: *p<0.05. Heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors in parentheses.

S3 Generalized Synthetic Control Models

S3.1 Model Explication and Alternative Estimators

The generalized synthetic control method (Xu 2017) models the level of affective polarization Y_{it} in each country i and year t as a function of a binary indicator for whether that country-year was “treated” by presidential institutions D_{it} :

$$Y_{it} = \delta_{it}D_{it} + X_{it}^{\top}\beta + \lambda_i^{\top}f_t + \varepsilon_{it}. \quad (\text{S1})$$

δ_{it} gives the heterogeneous treatment effect on country i in year t , β provides the effects of country-year covariates X_{it} , f_t is a vector of unobserved time-varying factors, λ_i is a vector of unit-specific factor loadings, and ε_{it} denotes random error. The key feature of this model is the interactive fixed effects (IFE) term $\lambda_i^{\top}f_t$, which allows each unit to follow its own trajectory over time by loading differentially on common latent factors.

This is a substantial generalization of the standard two-way fixed effects model, which restricts units to parallel trends conditional on covariates. The IFE estimator relaxes this assumption, but at the expense of assuming that all unobserved confounding is absorbed by the low-dimensional factor structure. That is, it assumes that any unobserved confounders are either time-invariant or vary over time in a way that is captured by the common factors. This is a strong assumption, but it is more flexible than parallel trends and allows for heterogeneous treatment effects across units and over time.

Estimation proceeds in three steps. In the first step, the model is estimated on never-treated observations to recover $\hat{\beta}$, $\hat{f}_t$, and $\hat{\lambda}_i$. The number of latent factors is selected via cross-validation, using mean squared prediction error (MSPE) based on the treated units’ pre-treatment periods as the validation criterion. In the second step, factor loadings for the treated unit are estimated by projecting its pre-treatment outcomes onto $\hat{f}_t$. In the third step, $\hat{\beta}$, $\hat{f}_t$, and $\hat{\lambda}_i$ are used to impute counterfactual outcomes for the treated unit in the post-treatment period—the “synthetic control” for the treated unit. The treatment effect for each post-treatment period is the difference between the observed and imputed outcomes, and the average treatment effect on the treated (ATT) averages these period-specific effects.

Unbalanced panels are accommodated naturally within this framework. When some country-year observations are missing, an EM-type algorithm iteratively imputes missing values and re-estimates the factor model until convergence. This is important here, as Figures S2 and S4 show that I do not have complete time series for all units.

The IFE estimator relies on four main assumptions. The first is strict exogeneity; conditional on factor structure and covariates, ε_{it} must be independent of treatment assignment in all periods. This rules out time-varying unobserved confounders that are not captured by the latent factors. Second, the factor structure must be low-rank—the number of latent factors must be small relative to the number of units and time periods. The cross-validation procedure identifies four latent factors—well within the bounds of the 38 countries and 27 years. Third, the treated unit cannot be so different from the controls that its counterfactual cannot be constructed as a weighted combination of control trajectories. The strong pre-treatment fit observed in main text Figure 1 suggests the model accurately tracks Israel’s affective polarization levels before treatment, and thus the control units likely provide adequate support for counterfactual imputation. Finally, the model assumes

no anticipation; units do not alter their behavior in response to future treatment. As discussed in the main text, I designate 1992 as the first treatment year precisely because parties likely began adjusting their strategies immediately after the reform passed, even though the first election under the new system did not occur until 1994. Other assumptions revolve around ε_{it} : they must weakly serially dependent, cross-sectionally independent, and homoskedastic (Xu 2017).

As noted in the main text, I use a parametric bootstrap with 1,000 iterations to obtain standard errors (Xu 2017). This procedure draws a pseudo-treated unit from the pool of control units, re-estimates the model to obtain simulated treatment effects, and uses the distribution of these simulated effects to construct a variance-covariance matrix for the residuals. Bootstrap errors are then drawn from this estimated covariance structure, preserving the serial correlation present in the original residuals. This approach avoids the downward bias that would result from a standard nonparametric bootstrap when the number of treated units is small.

I test two alternative estimators in addition to the IFE estimator above. The first is the matrix completion (MC) estimator (Athey et al. 2021). Rather than imposing a factor model and estimating factors explicitly, MC treats the matrix of potential outcomes as approximately low-rank and uses nuclear norm regularization to impute the counterfactual outcomes for treated units in post-treatment periods. The regularization strength is selected through cross-validation, again using MSPE as the criterion. Like the IFE estimator, MC is robust to violations of the parallel trends assumption, as it allows for heterogeneous trends driven by latent structure in the outcome.

However, since MC does not explicitly model the factor structure, a parametric bootstrap is not feasible—there are no residuals from which to estimate a covariance matrix and resample error series. Instead, I calculate standard errors using a jackknife procedure, which iteratively leaves out one control unit at a time and re-estimates the model. Unfortunately, with only 38 units, this procedure likely produces overly optimistic standard errors. The jackknife captures variation in the ATT due to which control units compose the donor pool, but it holds the treated unit fixed and only perturbs the controls. With a single treated unit, much of the uncertainty comes from the counterfactual imputation itself, but that uncertainty is not captured by the jackknife.

The second alternative is a generalized difference-in-differences (DID) estimator with two-way fixed effects. This model replaces the interactive fixed effects term $\lambda_i^\top f_t$ with additive unit and time fixed effects α_i and ξ_t :

$$Y_{it} = \delta_{it} D_{it} + X_{it}^\top \beta + \alpha_i + \xi_t + \varepsilon_{it}. \quad (\text{S2})$$

This is a more restrictive model that assumes parallel trends conditional on covariates and two-way fixed effects. Because it does not model unit-specific trajectories, it absorbs less systematic variation than the IFE estimator. As a result, the residuals tend to be larger and standard errors less precise. However, it serves as a useful benchmark: if the IFE and DID estimators yield similar point estimates, this suggests the treatment effect is not an artifact of the more flexible factor structure.

S3.2 Tabular Results

Table S5 presents the full tabular results of the models estimated in the main text, alongside the results of the alternative estimators. In each case, I present results with and without covariates. In general, controlling for covariates attenuates effect estimates only slightly, leaving substantive

conclusions unaffected. The first four columns show the results of the IFE estimator under the main coding scheme and the alternate coding scheme, respectively. The fifth and sixth columns show results from the MC estimator, and the last two columns show results from the DID estimator. Estimates are consistent across all three estimators, save for a slight dropoff in effect magnitude in the model using the alternate coding scheme. As discussed above, the MC and DID models produce standard errors that are likely depressed and inflated, respectively, and thus both should be interpreted with caution. However, the consistency of results across estimators suggests the robustness of the general finding that Israel's shift to direct election of the executive led to a reduction in affective polarization.

Table S5: Effect of Presidentialism on Affective Polarization across Counterfactual Estimators

	IFE		IFE (Alternate Coding)		Matrix Completion		Diff-in-Diff	
Presidential	−0.628*	−0.571*	−0.501*	−0.491*	−0.602*	−0.557*	−0.602	−0.557
	(0.231)	(0.227)	(0.241)	(0.238)	(0.054)	(0.083)	(0.413)	(0.318)
Democracy		−0.020		0.079		0.112		0.112
		(0.071)		(0.094)		(0.122)		(0.074)
GDP		0.092		0.399		0.017		0.017
		(0.214)		(0.243)		(0.183)		(0.271)
Gini		−0.171		−0.059		−0.088		−0.088
		(0.089)		(0.097)		(0.086)		(0.085)
Eff. Parties		−0.062		−0.268		−0.001		−0.001
		(0.139)		(0.149)		(0.140)		(0.151)
Total <i>N</i>	1026	1026	648	648	1026	1026	1026	1026
<i>N</i> Units	38	38	24	24	38	38	38	38
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

S3.3 Placebo Tests

I argue in the main text that there is strong theoretical reason to consider Israel's institutional reform a quasi-exogenous shock. Nevertheless, results could still be driven by pre-treatment trends, mechanical features of the synthetic control model, or other confounding factors present in Israel at the time. I conduct a series of placebo tests to assess the plausibility of these explanations. Following Eggers et al. (2024), I aim to replicate the main analysis as closely as possible, while altering either the treatment, outcome, or population in a way that should not produce a treatment effect if the identifying assumptions underlying the main analysis are valid.

First, the synthetic control model could be prone to generating spurious post-treatment divergence even when no institutional reform occurred. This could happen if the estimated effect merely reflects a pre-existing trend in affective polarization, unreliable counterfactual imputation, or some other feature of the underlying data. To test these possibilities, I conduct a series of placebo treatment tests in which I impose false treatment dates of 1983, 1986, and 1989, and fit the model to estimate trends in the remaining pre-treatment (that is, pre-1992) data. Since Israel was not, in

fact, treated in any of these years, the model should not detect a significant treatment effect in the post-treatment period.

Second, there could be persistent, pre-existing trends in affective polarization that the model does not account for, and that would have continued even in the absence of treatment. I therefore conduct a placebo outcome test in which I use the level of affective polarization lagged by 10 years as the dependent variable. Since it is impossible for the 1992 reform to affect affective polarization levels from 1982-1991, the model should not detect a significant treatment effect in this test.

Table S6 presents results from the placebo treatment and outcome tests. In all four models, the estimated treatment effect of presidentialism is small—with the possible exception of the 1983 treatment placebo—and statistically indistinguishable from zero. These results provide some reassurance that the main results are not driven by pre-treatment trends or mechanical features of the synthetic control model.

Table S6: Treatment and Outcome Placebo Tests

	Placebo Treatment			Placebo Outcome
	(1983)	(1986)	(1989)	(Lagged 10 Years)
Presidential	−0.214 (0.276)	−0.057 (0.292)	−0.107 (0.427)	0.047 (0.342)
Democracy	0.043 (0.099)	0.040 (0.098)	0.039 (0.099)	−0.080 (0.120)
GDP	0.563 (0.500)	0.572 (0.475)	0.571 (0.469)	0.339 (0.480)
Gini	0.070 (0.141)	0.069 (0.139)	0.070 (0.145)	−0.090 (0.150)
Eff. Parties	−0.301 (0.255)	−0.300 (0.258)	−0.298 (0.241)	−0.343 (0.209)
Total <i>N</i>	459	459	459	459
<i>N</i> Units	27	27	27	27
<i>N</i> Years	17	17	17	17

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

The placebo treatment and outcome tests in Table S6 are helpful for increasing confidence that Israel did, in fact, experience a decline in affective polarization around the time of the reform, but they cannot say *why* such a decline occurred. Israel experienced a number of other important political developments in the early 1990s: the negotiation of the Oslo Accords to end the First Intifada, mass immigration of ethnic Jews following the collapse of the Soviet Union, the assassination of Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin, and changing party system composition. More broadly, it would be reasonable to question whether changes in affective polarization could be due to institutional reform in general (rather than executive reform, specifically) or even to political changes writ large.

To test the degree to which these alternate explanations might contribute to the main results, I conduct a series of population placebo tests by finding other countries in the data that experienced similar political developments around the same time but did *not* experience any executive reform. Thus, any effects on affective polarization in these placebo units cannot be due to executive reform, but they may be attributable to other confounding factors. I identify five such placebo units:

Ireland's experience with the peace process following the Irish Republican Army's ceasefire in 1994, Germany's experience with mass immigration following national reunification in 1990 and the subsequent collapse of the Soviet Union, the assassination of Swedish Prime Minister Olof Palme in 1986, the breakdown of Greece's two-party system beginning with the election of 1990, and New Zealand's 1993 referendum to move from first-past-the-post voting to a mixed-member proportional electoral system.

Table S7 presents the results of these population placebo tests. None uncover statistically significant effect estimates. In the models of Ireland and Germany, this implies that neither the dynamics surrounding the peace process nor mass immigration were likely contributors to the robust decrease in affective polarization observed in Israel. The model evaluating the effect of political assassination in Sweden does show a large negative effect, but I cannot make a definitive statistical claim regarding the effect of assassination. It seems possible that Rabin's death in November 1995 could have contributed to a rally-round-the-flag effect in Israel, but any such effect still wouldn't have shown up in the data likely until 1996—nearly halfway into the post-treatment period.

Table S7: Population Placebo Tests of Alternate Explanations

	Peace Process (Ireland)	Mass Immigration (Germany)	PM Assassination (Sweden)	Party System Change (Greece)	Electoral Reform (New Zealand)
Presidential	−0.052 (0.326)	−0.012 (0.289)	−0.649 (0.417)	0.293 (0.307)	−0.399 (0.287)
Democracy	0.110 (0.083)	0.106 (0.077)	0.005 (0.075)	0.065 (0.076)	0.108 (0.078)
GDP	0.035 (0.258)	0.009 (0.258)	−0.040 (0.197)	0.083 (0.253)	−0.009 (0.274)
Gini	−0.090 (0.094)	−0.076 (0.102)	−0.124 (0.092)	−0.125 (0.102)	−0.081 (0.092)
Eff. Parties	0.001 (0.167)	0.028 (0.175)	0.024 (0.128)	−0.083 (0.151)	0.026 (0.172)
Total <i>N</i>	999	999	999	999	999
<i>N</i> Units	37	37	37	37	37
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

The model of Greece shows a positive effect, making it unlikely that the rising party system fragmentation in Israel contributed to any decline in polarization. Finally, New Zealand's electoral reform appears to have had a large negative effect on affective polarization, so it is difficult to rule out the possibility that any institutional reform could contribute to declining affective polarization while citizens reequilibrate their partisan identities and attitudes. However, the fact that Israel's reform held features of the electoral system constant casts doubt on the idea that electoral reform alone could have driven the decline in polarization. No one placebo test can definitively rule out all possible confounding factors but, collectively, they do provide reassurance that the main results are not driven by pre-treatment trends, model quirks, or other confounding factors.

S3.4 Incorporating Measurement Uncertainty

The polarization measures I use in the main text are estimated using a latent variable model (Mehlhaff 2025). Such variables are common in social science research, but recent contributions have warned against using them uncritically (e.g. Caughey and Warshaw 2018; Gandhi and Sumner 2020; Tai et al. 2024). Since latent variables are not directly observed but rather must be estimated, they come with some degree of measurement error around them. Failing to account for these errors in downstream analyses can, in some cases, lead to biased point estimates and overly confident uncertainty estimates. A common way to address this problem is to use the “method of composition,” which propagates uncertainty from the latent-variable estimation stage into downstream effect estimates (Solis and Waggoner 2021; Tanner 1993; Treier and Jackman 2008).

S3.4.1 Method of Composition

Let θ_{it} denote a latent quantity for country i in year t , and Y_{it} denote an observed outcome of interest. Suppose θ_{it} is estimated in a latent variable model using observed indicators Z_{it} . The posterior distribution of such an estimate would be $p(\theta_i | \mathbf{Z}_i)$, where $\theta_i = (\theta_{i1}, \dots, \theta_{iT})$ denotes the full time series for country i .

The downstream quantity of interest is the coefficient on presidential institutions, denoted δ in (S1) and (S2). δ is defined through a model such as $p(\mathbf{Y} | \theta, \delta)$. Rather than conditioning on a single point estimate $\hat{\theta}_{it}$, the method of composition integrates over measurement uncertainty in θ :

$$p(\delta | \mathbf{Y}, \mathbf{Z}) = \int p(\delta | \mathbf{Y}, \theta) p(\theta | \mathbf{Z}) d\theta. \quad (\text{S3})$$

In practice, this integral is approximated by Monte Carlo simulation. In each of 1,000 iterations, I draw a set of country-year latent polarization estimates from their respective posterior distributions, $\theta^{(m)} \sim p(\theta | \mathbf{Z}) \forall m \in 1, \dots, 1000$. I then use each of these 1,000 datasets to fit the downstream models, and finally draw a set of coefficients $\delta^{(m)}, \beta^{(m)}, \dots$ from the joint distribution of the fitted coefficient estimates and their covariance matrix. This process produces 1,000 estimates of $\hat{\delta}$, which approximate the posterior of δ .

S3.4.2 Preserving Temporal Dependence

PolarCAP provides standard errors of latent estimates in each country-year, making the posterior draw relatively straightforward. However, care must be taken to preserve any spatiotemporal dependence structure that is imposed in the latent variable models. PolarCAP models country-year latent estimates with a random walk, such that $\theta_{it} \sim N(\theta_{i,t-1}, q_i)$, where q_i is a country-specific variance capturing the volatility of the latent process. Simply drawing each $\theta_{it}^{(m)}$ independently from its marginal posterior distribution would therefore break temporal dependence, distort the variability of changes over time, and potentially bias downstream estimates. Using the method of composition with dynamic latent variables requires each draw $\theta^{(m)}$ to correspond to a full latent *trajectory* that preserves the temporal structure.

Full posterior draws of θ_i are not available, but I can approximate them using a simple state-space model that treats the posterior means as noisy observations of the latent state. Specifically, for each country i , I redefine a random walk process:

$$\mu_{it} = \theta_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (S4)$$

$$\varepsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma_{it}^2), \quad (S5)$$

where the observation variance σ_{it}^2 is fixed to the posterior variance for each country-year's polarization estimate. Note that this equation still depends on the unknown volatility parameter q_i , since $\theta_{it} \sim N(\theta_{i,t-1}, q_i)$. q_i is estimated once (and subsequently held constant across Monte Carlo iterations) using maximum likelihood via a Kalman filter. With $\hat{q}_i$ in hand, I can finally draw joint trajectories $\theta_i^{(m)} \sim p(\theta_i | \mu_i, \hat{q}_i)$. Each draw $\theta_i^{(m)}$ is a country-specific time series that respects temporal dependence and the measurement uncertainty introduced by the dynamic latent variable model.

S3.4.3 Results

Table S8 presents output from the synthetic control models after incorporating measurement error in estimates of affective polarization. I retrieve estimates for each estimator described above. The IFE point estimate attenuates slightly relative to the main estimate in Table S5, but the MC and DID estimates are almost exactly the same as those without measurement error incorporated. Both IFE and MC estimates remain statistically significant and in the expected direction. The DID estimate is not statistically significant, as in Table S5. Overall, propagating measurement error into downstream model estimates has no appreciable effect on substantive conclusions.

Table S8: Effect of Presidentialism on Affective Polarization across Counterfactual Estimators

	IFE	Matrix Completion	Diff-in-Diff
Presidential	−0.562* (0.252)	−0.558* (0.112)	−0.558 (0.327)
Democracy	−0.004 (0.078)	0.109 (0.125)	0.109 (0.077)
GDP	0.016 (0.222)	−0.018 (0.210)	−0.018 (0.267)
Gini	−0.169 (0.103)	−0.085 (0.093)	−0.085 (0.090)
Eff. Parties	−0.030 (0.148)	0.020 (0.146)	0.020 (0.154)
Total N	1026	1026	1026
N Units	38	38	38
N Years	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

S4 Party Brand and Organization Analyses

S4.1 Tabular Results

Tables S9 and S10 present the full tabular results of the models presented in main text Figure 2. Tables S11 and S12 present the results of the same models using the alternate coding scheme discussed in section S1. All models use parametrically bootstrapped standard errors, using the procedure described in section S3.1. Results are consistent across coding schemes, with all estimates statistically significant and in the expected directions.

Table S9: Effect of Presidentialism on Uncertainty of Party Policy Positions

	Immigration	Economic	Minority	Religious
Presidential	0.172* (0.030)	0.375* (0.035)	0.737* (0.027)	1.490* (0.064)
Democracy	−0.027* (0.011)	−0.042* (0.009)	−0.087* (0.013)	−0.096* (0.013)
GDP	−0.119* (0.016)	−0.138* (0.016)	−0.513* (0.021)	−0.134* (0.021)
Gini	−0.047* (0.006)	−0.025* (0.006)	−0.006 (0.007)	−0.012 (0.008)
Eff. Parties	0.037* (0.015)	−0.017 (0.011)	0.050* (0.014)	−0.101* (0.019)
Total <i>N</i>	999	999	999	999
<i>N</i> Units	37	37	37	37
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

Table S10: Effect of Presidentialism on Party Organization and Behavior

	Attack Oppo.	Local Offices	Local Activists	Personalization
Presidential	−0.606* (0.028)	−0.676* (0.044)	−0.353* (0.033)	0.502* (0.032)
Democracy	−0.168* (0.014)	0.047* (0.014)	0.040* (0.016)	0.092* (0.013)
GDP	−0.178* (0.019)	0.393* (0.025)	0.294* (0.022)	−0.199* (0.024)
Gini	0.114* (0.007)	−0.137* (0.009)	−0.183* (0.009)	0.020* (0.007)
Eff. Parties	−0.004 (0.018)	−0.303* (0.024)	−0.180* (0.025)	0.033 (0.018)
Total <i>N</i>	999	999	999	999
<i>N</i> Units	37	37	37	37
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

Table S11: Effect of Presidentialism on Uncertainty of Party Policy Positions (Alternate Coding)

	Immigration	Economic	Minority	Religious
Presidential	0.110* (0.021)	0.327* (0.056)	0.733* (0.020)	1.720* (0.031)
Democracy	-0.120* (0.011)	-0.052* (0.017)	-0.100* (0.015)	-0.102* (0.017)
GDP	-0.008 (0.018)	-0.245* (0.032)	-0.223* (0.020)	-0.011 (0.022)
Gini	-0.010 (0.005)	-0.034* (0.011)	-0.040* (0.007)	-0.140* (0.008)
Eff. Parties	0.117* (0.012)	0.014 (0.022)	0.029 (0.016)	-0.114* (0.017)
Total <i>N</i>	648	648	648	648
<i>N</i> Units	24	24	24	24
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

Table S12: Effect of Presidentialism on Party Organization and Behavior (Alternate Coding)

	Attack Oppo.	Local Offices	Local Activists	Personalization
Presidential	-0.659* (0.024)	-0.727* (0.033)	-0.252* (0.030)	0.480* (0.037)
Democracy	-0.232* (0.016)	0.093* (0.016)	0.149* (0.019)	-0.045 (0.024)
GDP	-0.264* (0.021)	0.248* (0.028)	0.287* (0.032)	0.328* (0.034)
Gini	0.217* (0.007)	-0.112* (0.009)	-0.198* (0.011)	-0.091* (0.011)
Eff. Parties	-0.004 (0.018)	-0.412* (0.023)	-0.359* (0.030)	0.061* (0.023)
Total <i>N</i>	648	648	648	648
<i>N</i> Units	24	24	24	24
<i>N</i> Years	27	27	27	27

Note: * $p < 0.05$.

S4.2 Permutation Tests

Figure S5 presents the results of permutation tests for each of the eight dependent variables in the party brand and organization analyses. In each case, the average treatment effect across all control units is approximately zero. The estimated treatment effect in Israel is almost always among the strongest treatment effects observed, with the only exceptions being on immigration and the presence of local activists. Moreover, comparing across dependent variables reveals that even when a control unit has a large effect on one variable, that effect almost never translates to other variables. Whereas Israel exhibits results that are consistently in the expected direction, the

control units do not. Taken together, these results indicate that the effects observed in Israel are not likely to be based on chance.

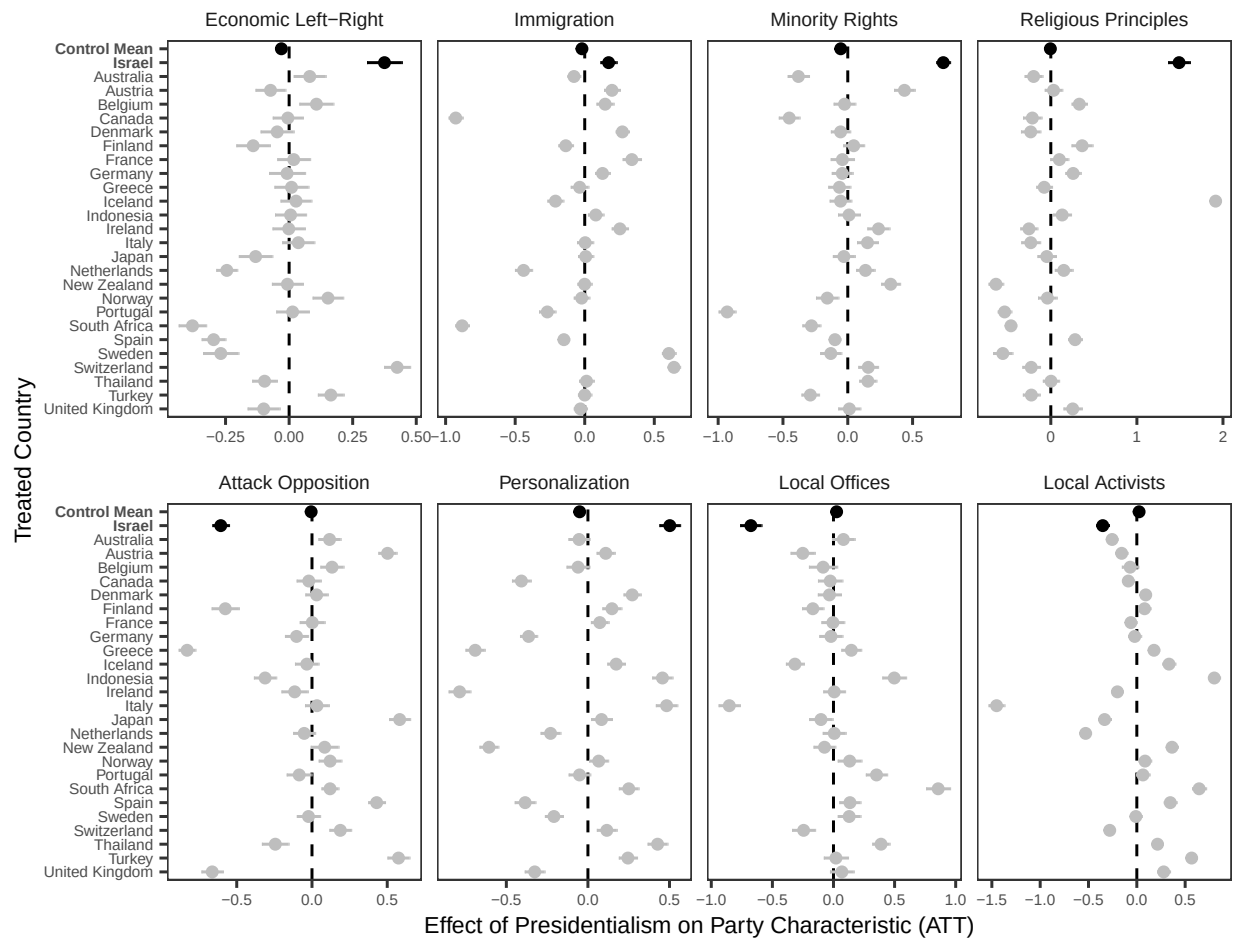


Figure S5: Permutation Test Results for Party Brand and Organization Analyses. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Table S13: Permutation Test p -Values for Party Brand and Organization Analyses

	One-Sided	Two-Sided
Immigration	0.24	0.44
Economic Left-Right	0.04	0.08
Minority Rights	0.00	0.04
Religious Principles	0.04	0.04
Attack Opposition	0.08	0.08
Local Offices	0.04	0.08
Local Activists	0.08	0.24
Personalization	0.00	0.12

Table S13 presents the p -values calculated from these permutation tests. Although many of them do not clear the $\alpha = 0.05$ threshold, I noted in the main text that these p -values are likely to be conservative. The fact that some control units lack a sufficient amount of pre-treatment data—as seen in Figure S2—means that the permutation p -values are calculated using a smaller number of units than the main analyses.

S5 Newspaper Sentiment Analyses

S5.1 Data Procurement

The ProQuest Historical Newspapers database contains digitized versions of all articles published in *The Jerusalem Post*. I restricted all database searches to the time period between January 1, 1975 and December 31, 2001. I identified articles related to politics, the economy, and culture through three separate searches. As such, some articles are represented in multiple categories because they mention multiple topics. 266,531 articles appear in only one search, while 35,786 appear in exactly two and 52 appear in all three. Figure S6 shows the number of articles published in each category by year, broken down by topic.

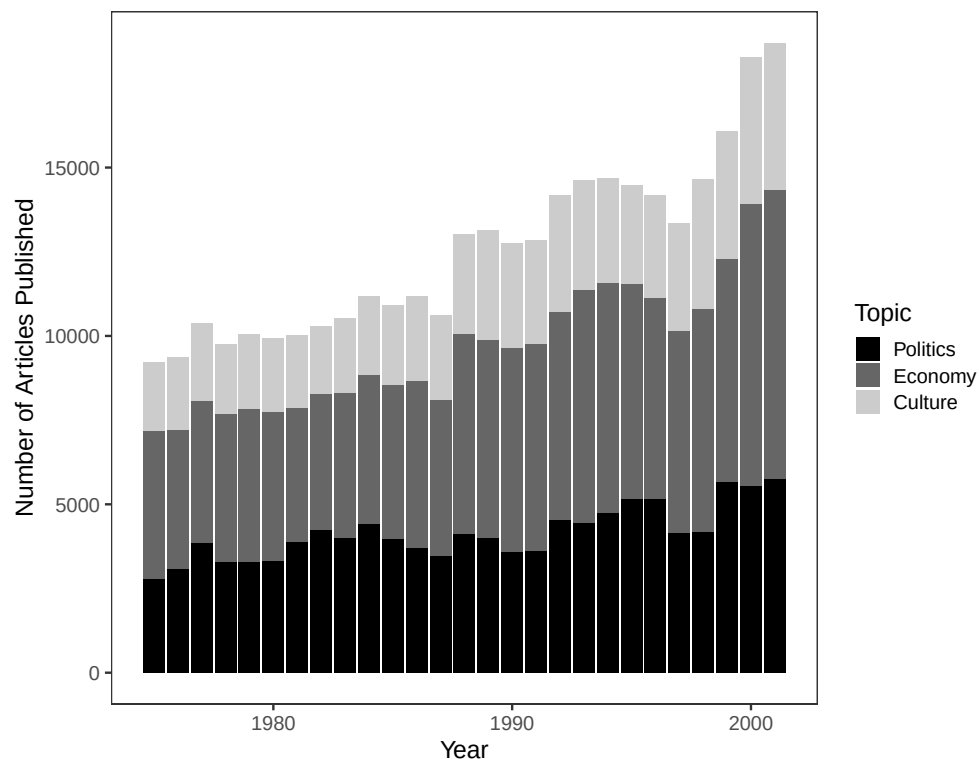


Figure S6: Number of Newspaper Articles Published by Topic

I used the search parameters displayed in Table S14 to identify articles relevant to each topic. In compiling the lists of parties and political leaders for the political topic search, I focused on the parties, coalitions, and leaders who actually held control of the executive or Knesset between

1975 and 2001. These are the parties and figures most likely to garner news coverage and to be the targets of affectively charged language. In constructing the search parameters for economic and cultural topics, I aimed to be as comprehensive as possible while avoiding terms that might be included in each category but also signal politics in some way. For example, I excluded terms like “budget” and “tax” from the economic search and “parties” and “peace” from the cultural search.

Table S14: Search Parameters for Newspaper Article Collection

Topic	Search Parameters
Politics	“alignment” OR “likud” OR “labor party” OR “one israel” OR “yitzhak rabin” OR “menachem begin” OR “yitzhak shamir” OR “shimon peres” OR “benjamin netanyahu” OR “ehud barak” OR “ariel sharon” OR kneset
Economy	(stock OR stocks OR market OR markets OR shares OR bond OR bonds OR inflation OR “interest rates” OR shekel OR dollar OR currency OR bank OR banks OR banking OR “Bank of Israel” OR trade OR exports OR imports OR industry OR industrial OR factory OR factories OR company OR companies OR corporate OR business OR profit OR profits OR earnings OR privatization OR investment OR investors OR wages OR “labor market” OR housing OR “real estate”) NOT (budget OR tax OR treasury OR “finance minister” OR “minister of finance” OR government OR Knesset OR coalition OR party OR election)
Culture	(music OR concert OR orchestra OR symphony OR opera OR theater OR theatre OR film OR movie OR cinema OR documentary OR festival OR art OR artist OR gallery OR museum OR exhibit OR exhibition OR book OR novel OR poetry OR poet OR author OR literature OR dance OR ballet OR cuisine OR restaurant OR chef OR fashion) NOT (election OR elections OR party OR parties OR Knesset OR government OR minister OR “prime minister” OR Netanyahu OR Peres OR Rabin OR Barak OR Sharon OR Labor OR Likud OR Meretz OR Shas OR coalition OR opposition OR cabinet OR bill OR law OR Palestinian OR peace OR Oslo OR terror OR Hamas OR PLO)

S5.2 Model Explication

To estimate the effect of the institutional reform on newspaper headline sentiment, I use interrupted time series (ITS) models. These models are designed for settings in which an outcome is observed repeatedly over time and a discrete intervention occurs at a known point, partitioning the time series into pre- and post-intervention periods (Anderton and Carter 2001; Bates et al. 2017; Cross and Bølstad 2015). Because I observe headlines at the article level across 27 years, with the institutional reform occurring in 1992, ITS is a natural fit.

The sentiment Y_t of each headline published at time t is modeled as:

$$Y_t = \beta_0 + \beta_1 T_t + \beta_2 D_t + \beta_3 P_t + \varepsilon_t, \quad (\text{S6})$$

where T_t is the number of years elapsed since the beginning of the observation period (January 1, 1975), D_t is a binary indicator equal to 1 during the period of direct executive elections (1992–2001), and P_t is the number of years elapsed since the reform (and is zero in pre-reform periods). β_0 is the intercept, representing the baseline level of sentiment at the start of the observation period. β_1 captures the pre-treatment trend in sentiment—that is, the rate at which sentiment was increasing or decreasing before the reform. β_2 captures the immediate level shift in sentiment at the time of the reform. β_3 , the coefficient of primary interest, captures the *sustained* change in the outcome’s trajectory following the reform. A statistically significant β_3 indicates that the reform altered the rate at which sentiment changed over time, above and beyond any pre-existing trend.

As discussed in the main text, I focus on β_3 rather than β_2 because the effect of institutional change on media content is unlikely to be instantaneous; rather, party behavior should gradually change over time as parties adapt to new electoral incentives. I report Newey–West standard errors to account for heteroskedasticity and autocorrelation (Newey and West 1987).

The ITS design relies on four main assumptions (e.g. Baicker and Svoronos 2019). First, time trends can be expressed as a linear combination of parameters. Second, the pre-treatment level and trend in sentiment would have been the same regardless of whether the reform had occurred. Third, if the reform had not occurred, the pre-treatment trend would have continued unchanged into the post-treatment period. The biggest threat to the validity of this parallel trends assumption is perhaps also the threat to the final assumption—that there are no other events coinciding with the reform that could have caused a change in sentiment.

I discuss in the main text that the *The Jerusalem Post* changed ownership in 1989, which could have affected the newspaper’s editorial stance. However, the shift to the political right that occurred in the years immediately following the change in ownership likely would have pushed the newspaper to evoke harder stances, more polarized sentiment regarding parties and political leaders, and less subjective language—the opposite of what I expect theoretically and find empirically. While the *point estimate* of the reform’s effect may still be biased toward zero, the strong and statistically significant results suggest the *direction* of the effect is likely to be robust to this potential confounder.

S5.3 Tabular Results

In the main text, I presented only the results for the parameters of interest in order to keep the tables manageable. Tables S15, S16, and S17 present full results for the ITS models of newspaper headline sentiment regarding political, economic, and cultural topics, respectively.

Table S15: Interrupted Time Series Models of Newspaper Headline Sentiment (Politics)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Subjectivity	Neutral	Negative	Positive
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Time	0.001 (0.001)	−0.004* (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)
Reform	−0.005 (0.012)	0.024* (0.012)	−0.030* (0.012)	0.0003 (0.012)
Time Since Reform	−0.009* (0.002)	0.010* (0.002)	−0.005* (0.002)	−0.008* (0.002)
Intercept	0.009 (0.009)	0.026* (0.008)	−0.014 (0.008)	−0.021* (0.008)
Observations	111,785	111,785	111,785	111,785

Note: * $p < 0.05$. Newey-West standard errors in parentheses.

Table S16: Interrupted Time Series Models of Newspaper Headline Sentiment (Economy)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Subjectivity	Neutral	Negative	Positive
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Time	−0.003* (0.001)	0.004* (0.001)	−0.004* (0.001)	−0.001* (0.001)
Reform	−0.052* (0.010)	0.077* (0.010)	−0.068* (0.010)	−0.033* (0.010)
Time Since Reform	0.004* (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.002 (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)
Intercept	0.058* (0.008)	−0.093* (0.007)	0.095* (0.008)	0.028* (0.007)
Observations	149,493	149,493	149,493	149,493

Note: * $p < 0.05$. Newey-West standard errors in parentheses.

Table S17: Interrupted Time Series Models of Newspaper Headline Sentiment (Culture)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Subjectivity	Neutral	Negative	Positive
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Time	−0.004* (0.001)	0.005* (0.001)	−0.005* (0.001)	−0.002* (0.001)
Reform	−0.056* (0.014)	0.063* (0.014)	0.012 (0.014)	−0.087* (0.014)
Time Since Reform	0.004* (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.004* (0.002)	0.005* (0.002)
Intercept	0.082* (0.011)	−0.110* (0.011)	0.087* (0.011)	0.064* (0.011)
Observations	76,981	76,981	76,981	76,981

Note: * $p < 0.05$. Newey-West standard errors in parentheses.

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